the closures and paralysis of giant industrial complexes as well as the rise in price of Chinese products that are increasingly consumed the world over.

In order to access and control petroleum resources, China has created three gigantic multinationals: the China National Offshore Oil Corporation (CNOOC), the China National Petroleum Corporation (CNPC) and the China Petroleum and Chemical Corporation (SINOPEC). In parallel, the National Bank of China has been able to negotiate loans and purchases with countries that are the objects of investment and has often not been able to or wanted to access World Bank or International Monetary Fund (IMF) credits. Nevertheless, control over petroleum is not an easy task. China even faces conflicts over the crude oil reserves in its seas, a controversy aggravated by the United States' efforts to curb Chinese expansion.

China in Ecuador

The Ecuadorian Amazon is an area of important Chinese investment in the construction of hydroelectric dams, in petroleum exploration and in mineral reserves. It is possible to think of a giant Asian enclave that occupies no less than one-third of Ecuador and also extends to a large part of the Peruvian Amazon. The conditions for this land grab have to be looked for in the crisis created by the neoliberal model.

Decades of IMF and World Bank loans to Ecuador facilitated US interference at the national level as economic and social policies were subjected to the conditions laid down by the aforementioned loans. On occasion there were governments that accepted the credit institutions' guidelines and renounced state budgetary planning. Thus Ecuador's economy was hardly autonomous and, moreover, depended basically on the export of petroleum resources. The World Bank and IMF were functional for US oil capital because their guidelines served their oil firms and guaranteed them access to the petroleum reserves.

In contrast to what happens with the United States and the traditional credit institutions, the relationship with Chinese banks and companies, even though they belong to the Chinese state, is openly mediated by the state and their impact is more obvious and direct. Secondly, China's foreign oil policy has few qualms about the type of government it conducts business with. The only thing that interests it is access to petroleum reserves and that expenses are cheaper for the Chinese state. According to official figures, Ecuador's debt with China is more than US$10 billion. Much of this debt forms part of the 'commercial operations' with the State Oil Company. The guarantee of repayment would be the petroleum and the loans often carry high interest rates.